

Explain It Like You Built It

How relative paths and Netlify deployment actually work

When I open **proof-page.html** on my own computer, only I can see it — the file just sits on my machine. Inside the HTML, there's a line like **src="screenshots/login.png"** that tells the browser where to find an image. That path isn't a fixed location; it's relative to wherever the HTML file itself is sitting. So the browser starts from the HTML file's folder and looks for a **screenshots** folder right next to it. If that folder isn't in the right place, the image just breaks — there's nothing pointing the browser to it.

When I dragged my whole folder into Netlify, it didn't just give me a link to my own computer. Netlify copied my files onto its own servers, which stay on 24/7 — unlike my laptop, which I can turn off or disconnect from WiFi. The link Netlify gave me points to that copy, not to my machine, which is why the site keeps working even when my computer is off. And the same relative-path rule still applies on Netlify's server — it's just that "the folder the HTML lives in" is now Netlify's server instead of my Desktop.